PRACTICE EXAM 01 / EXAM SET 01

Domain 1: Foundational Knowledge and Basic Science

15 scored questions	4 answer choices per question	Answer key + explanations included

Instructions

Choose the single best answer (A, B, C, or D) for each question. Mark your responses before checking the answer key and detailed explanations at the end of this document. These practice questions are not official NHA examination items.

QUESTIONS

Q01 | Health Care Systems and Settings

> **SCENARIO** During intake at a community clinic, a patient says that an eviction notice and difficulty obtaining food are interfering with follow-up visits. The clinic has a social worker, a registered dietitian, a radiologic technologist, and a laboratory technician.

Which team member is best positioned to help the patient identify housing assistance and food-access resources?

A. The registered dietitian.
B. The radiologic technologist.
C. The social worker.
D. The laboratory technician.

Q02 | Medical Terminology

How does the suffix in appendectomy differ from the suffix in tracheotomy?

A. -ectomy means surgical removal; -otomy means an incision into.
B. -ectomy means an incision into; -otomy means surgical removal.
C. -ectomy means surgical repair; -otomy means surgical fixation.
D. -ectomy means visual examination; -otomy means surgical repair.

Q03 | Basic Pharmacology

SCENARIO A provider orders amoxicillin 500 mg orally once now for an adult patient. The available suspension contains 400 mg per 5 mL. The medical assistant is trained and authorized to administer this medication under applicable law and clinic policy. An oral syringe measures in 0.1 mL increments.

What volume should be prepared? Round to the nearest 0.1 mL, rounding a halfway value up.

A. 1.3 mL

B. 4 mL

C. 5 mL

D. 6.3 mL

Q04 | Psychology

SCENARIO A 4-year-old arriving for a routine examination hides behind a parent and says the examination table might swallow children. There is no urgent medical concern, and a toy examination kit is available.

Which response best addresses the developmental factor affecting this visit?

A. Explain the equipment using a detailed diagram of its internal parts.

B. Use simple, concrete words and let the child examine a doll with the toy kit.

C. Ask the parent to explain that children this age should understand the equipment.

D. Give the child a long list of all procedures that might occur during the visit.

Q05 | Health Care Systems and Settings

Which statement correctly distinguishes professional certification from occupational licensure?

A. Certification grants state legal authority, while licensure documents an employer's training.

B. Certification recognizes defined qualifications, while licensure provides governmental authorization to practice where required.

C. Certification grants independent prescribing authority, while licensure limits practice to supervised tasks.

D. Certification is issued by the hiring clinic, while licensure is issued by a national testing company.

Q06 | Basic Pharmacology

SCENARIO A patient with difficulty swallowing asks whether an extended-release tablet can be crushed into applesauce. The product label states, "Swallow whole. Do not crush or chew." The prescriber has not ordered an alternative formulation.

Which response should the medical assistant give?

A. Crush the tablet only if the patient takes the mixture immediately.

B. Dissolve the tablet in warm water to preserve its release mechanism.

C. Explain the label restriction and request a pharmacist or prescriber review of a suitable alternative.

D. Replace it with the same milligram strength of an immediate-release product.

Q07 | Nutrition

SCENARIO A patient's written nutrition plan limits sodium to 600 mg at lunch. A soup label lists 280 mg of sodium per serving and 2.5 servings per container. The patient plans to eat the entire container with no other lunch foods.

Which statement accurately connects the label to the existing plan?

A. The container supplies 700 mg of sodium, which exceeds the lunch limit by 100 mg.
B. The container supplies 280 mg of sodium, which leaves 320 mg within the lunch limit.
C. The container supplies 560 mg of sodium, which leaves 40 mg within the lunch limit.
D. The container supplies 112 mg of sodium, which leaves 488 mg within the lunch limit.

Q08 | Medical Terminology

SCENARIO An intake note describes an abrasion on the left forearm proximal to the wrist. The medical assistant needs to understand the location before showing the note to the provider.

What does proximal to the wrist mean in this note?

A. Toward the fingertips from the left wrist.
B. Toward the elbow from the right wrist.
C. Directly over the joint of the left wrist.
D. Toward the elbow from the left wrist.

Q09 | Health Care Systems and Settings

SCENARIO A family medicine provider refers a patient to a cardiologist's office for evaluation of a newly detected heart murmur. The patient will attend a scheduled visit and return home afterward.

Which type of service does this referral represent?

A. Inpatient general medical care.
B. Emergency stabilization services.
C. Specialty outpatient care.
D. Residential rehabilitative care.

Q10 | Psychology

SCENARIO During a routine visit, a patient who recently lost a job repeatedly loses track of the conversation and says, "I keep thinking about how I will pay the bills." The patient is alert and reports that this difficulty began during the current period of stress.

Which explanation best accounts for why the patient may have trouble recalling information from this visit?

A. Stress increases the amount of unfamiliar information retained during a visit.
B. Financial worry primarily affects willingness to cooperate rather than attention.
C. The new recall difficulty is most consistent with a progressive memory disorder.
D. Stress-related worry can compete for attention and interfere with learning.

Q11 | Basic Pharmacology

SCENARIO During medication reconciliation, a patient taking lisinopril for hypertension says, "I bought potassium tablets for leg cramps and want to start them tonight." The medical assistant has not received an order or approval for the supplement.

Which statement best explains why the planned supplement needs clinician review?

A. Potassium replacement is routinely required because lisinopril causes potassium loss.
B. The combination may increase potassium because lisinopril is an ACE inhibitor.
C. Taking potassium at a different time would remove the need for interaction review.
D. The supplement has little interaction potential because it is sold without a prescription.

Q12 | Medical Terminology

SCENARIO A clinic policy requires staff to spell out the word units in medication documentation because handwritten U may be misread. An authorized insulin order specifies a dose of eight units. The assistant is entering the dose field exactly as ordered, without changing the prescription.

Which entry follows the stated abbreviation policy?

A. 8 U
B. 8 u
C. 8 units
D. 8 IU

Q13 | Nutrition

SCENARIO A patient with a prescribed nutrition plan for inadequate dietary intake brings a bottle advertised as a natural meal-replacement supplement. The patient wants to replace the planned meals with the product. Its ingredients and nutrient amounts have not been reviewed by the care team.

Which response best supports the existing nutrition plan?

A. Use the product in place of planned meals if it contains added vitamins.
B. Bring the product label to the clinician or dietitian before changing the plan.
C. Select the product dose by matching its calorie count to one meal.
D. Use the product in place of planned meals because natural ingredients establish safety.

Q14 | Basic Pharmacology

SCENARIO A medication reference states that a patient's oral medicine is absorbed from the gastrointestinal tract, metabolized in the liver, and eliminated mainly through the kidneys. The chart documents a recent reduction in kidney function. The provider will review the medication regimen.

Which pharmacokinetic concern should the assistant understand when flagging this information for review?

A. Reduced kidney function may directly prevent the tablet from dissolving in the stomach.
B. Reduced kidney function may accelerate the medicine's chemical breakdown in the liver.
C. Reduced kidney function may prevent the absorbed medicine from entering the bloodstream.
D. Reduced kidney function may slow excretion and allow the medicine to accumulate.

Q15 | Basic Pharmacology

SCENARIO A trained medical assistant, authorized under applicable law and clinic policy, is checking an order for ondansetron 4 mg once now. The order does not specify a route. The clinic stocks both oral and injectable formulations, and its policy requires the route to be specified before medication preparation.

Which action addresses the unresolved medication-administration right?

A. Choose the oral route because an oral formulation is in stock.
B. Ask the ordering provider to clarify the route before preparing the dose.
C. Ask the patient which route was used during a previous visit and follow it.
D. Choose the injectable route because the order says once now.

ANSWER KEY & EXPLANATIONS

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01 C	02 A	03 D	04 B	05 B	06 C
07 A	08 D	09 C	10 D	11 B	12 C
13 B	14 D	15 B			

DETAILED EXPLANATIONS

Q01 | Correct answer: C

The social worker.

A social worker can help identify community resources and address social barriers to care. A dietitian can evaluate nutritional needs, but housing assistance and access to social services are the central needs in this situation.

Q02 | Correct answer: A

-ectomy means surgical removal; -otomy means an incision into.

The suffix -ectomy identifies surgical removal, whereas -otomy identifies cutting into a structure. The root identifies the structure involved; changing the suffix changes the procedure described.

Q03 | Correct answer: D

6.3 mL

The volume is (500 mg / 400 mg) x 5 mL = 6.25 mL, which rounds to 6.3 mL using the stated rule. Preparing 5 mL would provide only 400 mg, less than the ordered dose.

Q04 | Correct answer: B

Use simple, concrete words and let the child examine a doll with the toy kit.

Preschool children may interpret unfamiliar events through imaginative thinking. Brief, concrete explanations and play can make the experience more understandable; detailed technical information or a long list of possibilities may increase confusion.

Q05 | Correct answer: B

Certification recognizes defined qualifications, while licensure provides governmental authorization to practice where required.

Certification recognizes that an individual has met a certifying organization's requirements. Licensure is governmental authorization to practice an occupation where required; holding a certification does not itself expand a medical assistant's legal scope.

Q06 | Correct answer: C

Explain the label restriction and request a pharmacist or prescriber review of a suitable alternative.

The supplied product instructions prohibit crushing or chewing this tablet. Altering its release mechanism can change drug delivery; the pharmacist or prescriber should evaluate an alternative rather than the assistant modifying or substituting the product.

Q07 | Correct answer: A

The container supplies 700 mg of sodium, which exceeds the lunch limit by 100 mg.

Multiply 280 mg per serving by 2.5 servings to obtain 700 mg per container. This is 100 mg above the prescribed 600 mg lunch limit; using the per-serving value alone understates the intake.

Q08 | Correct answer: D

Toward the elbow from the left wrist.

Proximal means closer to the point of attachment of a limb to the trunk. From the left wrist, the direction toward the elbow is proximal; the direction toward the fingertips is distal.

Q09 | Correct answer: C

Specialty outpatient care.

The cardiologist provides care focused on a particular organ system, making the service specialty care. A scheduled office evaluation without admission is outpatient care; referral to a specialist does not by itself imply an inpatient or emergency visit.

Q10 | Correct answer: D

Stress-related worry can compete for attention and interfere with learning.

Stress can consume attention and reduce how much new information a patient takes in. The observations support recognizing a learning barrier, not labeling the patient uncooperative or diagnosing a permanent cognitive condition.

Q11 | Correct answer: B

The combination may increase potassium because lisinopril is an ACE inhibitor.

Lisinopril is an angiotensin-converting enzyme (ACE) inhibitor, and potassium supplements can increase the risk of elevated potassium when used with it. The assistant should document and report the planned supplement so the clinician can review it; sale without a prescription does not establish that a supplement is safe to combine with a medication.

Q12 | Correct answer: C

8 units

The entry 8 units spells out the intended dose unit as required by the supplied policy. U, u, and IU do not follow that policy and can create ambiguity; changing the wording of the unit must not change the ordered dose.

Q13 | Correct answer: B

Bring the product label to the clinician or dietitian before changing the plan.

The care team should review the product's ingredients and nutritional adequacy before it replaces prescribed meals. A natural claim or added vitamins does not establish that a supplement is safe or nutritionally equivalent to the existing plan.

Q14 | Correct answer: D

Reduced kidney function may slow excretion and allow the medicine to accumulate.

For a medicine eliminated mainly through the kidneys, reduced kidney function can decrease excretion and increase exposure to the drug or its metabolites. Absorption moves medicine into the bloodstream, while metabolism chemically changes it; the supplied evidence concerns elimination and does not authorize the assistant to change the dose.

Q15 | Correct answer: B

Ask the ordering provider to clarify the route before preparing the dose.

The right route cannot be verified from an order that omits it, especially when more than one formulation is available. The ordering provider must clarify the route; urgency wording, available stock, or a previous visit does not supply the missing authorization.

End of Practice Exam